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CONTACT ONE-SHEET · IBM WATSONX · SEPTEMBER 15, 2026

Arvind Krishna

Chairman & CEO, IBM

Not disclosed

Revenue

Armonk

HQ

01 Who You're Meeting

Arvind Krishna — Chairman & CEO, IBM, IBM watsonx.**In role:** CEO since April 2020; Chairman since January 2021**Today:** Leads IBM overall, with the hybrid cloud and AI strategy — watsonx, Red Hat and the generative AI book of business — as the centre of it.

A researcher who rose to run the company, which is rare at IBM's scale and shapes how technical a conversation with him can be. He joined IBM in 1990 at the Thomas J. Watson Research Center and spent twenty-five years in research and technical leadership before being promoted to Senior Vice President in 2015, running IBM Cloud & Cognitive Software and IBM Research. He was the principal architect of the Red Hat acquisition, the largest in IBM's history, which is the foundation of the hybrid cloud strategy he now runs the company on. He holds a doctorate from the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign.

Career: Chairman, IBM; Chief Executive Officer, IBM; Senior Vice President, IBM Cloud & Cognitive Software and IBM Research, IBM; Research and technical leadership, from the Thomas J. Watson Research Center, IBM

Education: PhD, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign; BTech, Indian Institute of Technology Kanpur

The company: A governance-first enterprise AI platform riding IBM's existing enterprise relationships rather than a vertical infrastructure play — the most horizontal (industry-agnostic) offering on this list.

What they sell: watsonx.ai (foundation-model studio), watsonx.data (data lakehouse) and watsonx.governance (AI lifecycle/risk/compliance), built around IBM's Granite models plus open-source and third-party models.

02 Where The Company Sits

Overlaps with Sand mainly on AI governance and enterprise deployment discipline, not on physical-infrastructure control; IBM's brand and balance sheet dwarf every other name here except Siemens.

03 Talking Points

- Twenty-five years in IBM Research before management — he can go deep on architecture, and expects the other side to keep up.
- watsonx.governance is the part of the stack most enterprises are least equipped for; that is the strongest opening rather than model capability.
- The generative AI book of business is a cumulative inception-to-date figure spanning software, SaaS and consulting signings. Do not treat it as annual revenue in front of him.

What to pressure-test about the company:

- Some internal reviewers note limited hands-on usage — one employee described watsonx training as done “for the sake of training” with little real deployment exposure
- Complex initial user experience flagged by Gartner Peer Insights reviewers, especially for less technical teams
- No physical-infrastructure specialization — competes as a horizontal platform against nimbler vertical specialists

04 GIP Context

GIP: No connection found. IBM's enterprise client base is broad enough that overlap with a GIP portfolio company is plausible, but no specific relationship was confirmed in available sources.

BlackRock: Confirmed passive ownership — BlackRock holds a ~\$18.8B stake in IBM (77.6M shares as of Q1 2026), its largest institutional holder ahead of Vanguard and State Street.

Others at IBM watsonx: Rob Thomas (Senior VP, Software & Chief Commercial Officer)

www.ibm.com/watsonx · [IBM Q4 2025 results](#) · [IBM SEC filing](#) · [Company LinkedIn](#)

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